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Lots

4.9 Lots

References:

Hebrew גּוֹרָל (goral) LEV 16:8, LEV 16:8, LEV 16:8, LEV 16:9, LEV 16:10, NUM 26:55, NUM 26:56, NUM 33:54, NUM 33:54, NUM 34:13, NUM 36:2, NUM 36:3, JOS 14:2, JOS 15:1, JOS 16:1, JOS 17:1, JOS 17:14, JOS 17:17, JOS 18:6, JOS 18:8, JOS 18:10, JOS 18:11, JOS 18:11, JOS 19:1, JOS 19:10, JOS 19:17, JOS 19:24, JOS 19:32, JOS 19:40, JOS 19:51, JOS 21:4, JOS 21:4, JOS 21:5, JOS 21:6, JOS 21:8, JOS 21:10, JOS 21:20, JOS 21:40, JDG 1:3, JDG 1:3, JDG 20:9, 1CH 6:39, 1CH 6:46, 1CH 6:48, 1CH 6:50, 1CH 24:5, 1CH 24:7, 1CH 24:31, 1CH 25:8, 1CH 25:9, 1CH 26:13, 1CH 26:14, 1CH 26:14, 1CH 26:14, NEH 10:35, NEH 11:1, EST 3:7, EST 9:24, PSA 16:5, PSA 22:19, PSA 125:3, PRO 1:14, PRO 16:33, PRO 18:18, ISA 17:14, ISA 34:17, ISA 57:6, JER 13:25, EZK 24:6, DAN 12:13, JOL 4:3, OBA 1:11, JON 1:7, JON 1:7, JON 1:7, MIC 2:5, NAM 3:10

Greek κλῆρος (klēros) MAT 27:35, MRK 15:24, LUK 23:34, JHN 19:24, ACT 1:26, ACT 1:26, ACT 8:21, ESG 3:7, ESG 3:7, SIR 14:15, SIR 25:19, SIR 37:8

Greek (lagchanō (verb)) LUK 1:9, JHN 19:24

Description and usage:

Pottery shard lots (© Eliot from The Negev, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons)Lots were specially marked pebbles, pieces of pottery or sticks used in making decisions. It is not possible to know the particular method used in "choosing by lot," for evidently various devices were used. See also 4.9.1 Urim and Thummim<REALIA:4.9.1>.

Translation:

Drawing lots (literally "throwing lots" in Hebrew) was viewed by the people of Israel as a way of discerning God's will, since it was believed that God directed the outcome (see PRO 16:33). In some cultures the closest natural equivalents of deciding by lot are procedures involving "drawing straws," "throwing down sticks," and "dropping pebbles."

JHN 19:24: "Throw dice" (GNT, JB, NAB) translates the Greek verb *lagchanō*, which means to get something either by casting or drawing lots (so RSV, Mft, AT, Phps). However, for contemporary readers the idea of throwing dice or tossing a coin may be the nearest cultural equivalent; for example, for the third clause in this verse NEB has "let us toss for it." In some languages a generic expression may be employed, for example, "let us gamble for it." However, in some parts of the world where there is no cultural equivalent of gambling, a parallel type of behavior can be described, for example, "let us play a game to see who wins and therefore gets the robe."

In ACT 1:26RSV "they cast lots for them" is literally "they gave them lots" in Greek. In this context it is probable that small sticks were handed out.